

WHAT THE US WANTS TO SELL INDIA



BOEING P-8I POSEIDON The navy has begun price negotiations for eight aircraft worth an estimated Rs 8,800 crore to be delivered in 2012



C-130J HERCULES The IAF is buying six of these troop transport aircraft worth an estimated Rs 4,000 crore to ferry army's special forces



BOEING F/A 18 S HORNET One of the contenders in the lucrative Rs 40,000 crore bid to supply 126 fighter aircraft to the IAF

SANDEEP UNNITHAN



F-16 FIGHTING FALCON One of six contenders vying for the 126 aircraft contract, though sales to Pakistan may dampen its chances

on how to get it done domestically and we are willing to work with it in that framework."

India has so far refused to sign a US-driven post 9/11 security-related initiative—the Proliferation Security Initiative (PSI)—which calls for boarding and searching of merchant vessels with suspicious cargo in international waters and also refused to join Task Force 150—a multinational task force which pursues vessels as part of the US-led war on terror. This is because these initiatives are not UN-authorised. One less controversial post-9/11 security agreement that India is preparing is the Container Security Initiative (CSI) where US inspectors screen and seal containers bound for its shores for potentially dangerous cargo. The Jawaharlal Nehru Port Trust (JNPT), which accounts for the bulk of India's container cargo, will join a list of 47 international ports which are signatories to the CSI and becomes the first Indian port to host US officials when the agreement is signed.

India has expressed concerns at the end-user agreement which insists on US inspectors verifying sensitive military equipment is not transferred to third parties. "We have objected to such an arrangement and have instead agreed to supply them end-user certificates," says a senior official in the Ministry of Defence. However, India may eventually sign the Communication Interoperability and Security Memorandum of Agreement (CISMOA)—a must for all countries that purchase sophisticated command and control equipment—if it is to receive high-tech US equipment like the P-8I Poseidon aircraft. It allows for interoperability with US equipment.

But the key would be major arms sales especially the multi-role fighter that the US is making an all-out bid to bag. The US argument is that it has never had a major military relationship with a country that has not been a major buyer of its defence hardware. India is convinced about the technological prowess of US military hardware but cites the trust deficit and US policy which can deny spares support for this equipment during war. Clearly, it will be years before the results of the new Gates mission are realised. ■